

16-Week Marathon Training Diet Plan

Lean Out 10-15 lbs While Training for Your 3:50:00 Marathon (Oct 18, 2026)

Training start: June 29, 2026 | **Race day:** October 18, 2026 | **Goal:** Lose 10-15 lbs of fat while maintaining/improving running performance

How This Plan Works

Losing weight while marathon training is a balancing act: too aggressive a calorie deficit and your long runs fall apart, recovery stalls, and you risk injury. This plan uses a **modest, phase-adjusted deficit (~300-500 cal/day)** that tightens slightly in low-mileage weeks and relaxes during peak mileage and race week, so you fuel the work without stalling fat loss. Expect roughly **0.75-1 lb/week**, which lands you at 10-15 lbs by race day.

Core principles: - **Protein stays high year-round** (0.7-0.9 g per lb bodyweight) to preserve muscle in a deficit. - **Carbs scale up on hard/long-run weeks**, down on easy weeks — same recipes, different portion sizes. - **Fat stays moderate and consistent** — it's the easiest lever to trim without hurting performance. - **One recipe library, reused all 16 weeks.** You'll get fast at cooking these, batch-prep goes up, and grocery bills stay predictable.

Phase Overview & Daily Targets

Phase	Weeks	Training Focus	Daily Calories*	Protein	Carbs	Fat	Deficit
Base	1-4	Build mileage base, easy aerobic runs	1,900-2,100	150g	190-220g	60g	~500 cal
Build	5-10	Tempo runs, hill work, mileage climbs	2,100-2,400	160g	230-280g	65g	~400 cal
Peak	11-14	Longest runs (18-20mi), highest volume	2,300-2,600	165g	260-310g	70g	~300 cal
Taper	15-16	Mileage drops sharply, race prep	2,000-2,200	150g	200-240g	60g	~350 cal

Targets assume a 160-190 lb runner; adjust ±200 cal based on your size and how recovery/weight trend looks after week 2. Long-run days within any phase add 200-400 carb-calories (extra rice/potato/fruit) — don't run a 18-miler underfueled to chase a number on the scale.*

⚠ **Stop the deficit, don't push through, if:** you miss 2+ consecutive nights of sleep from hunger, your easy-pace heart rate creeps up unexplained, your weight drops faster than 1.5 lb/week, or you feel persistently flat on runs. Bump calories up 200-300/day and reassess.

16-Week Tracking & Checklist Chart

Print this page and check off each week as you go — weight is a 7-day average, not a single morning reading.

Week	Dates (from 6/29)	Phase	Long Run	Target Cal/Day	Starting Weight	Week-End Weight (7-day avg)	Done ✓
1	Jun 29 – Jul 5	Base	6 mi	1,950	_____	_____	☐
2	Jul 6 – Jul 12	Base	7 mi	1,950	_____	_____	☐
3	Jul 13 – Jul 19	Base	8 mi	2,000	_____	_____	☐
4	Jul 20 – Jul 26	Base (recovery)	6 mi	2,050	_____	_____	☐
5	Jul 27 – Aug 2	Build	10 mi	2,150	_____	_____	☐
6	Aug 3 – Aug 9	Build	11 mi	2,150	_____	_____	☐
7	Aug 10 – Aug 16	Build	12 mi	2,200	_____	_____	☐
8	Aug 17 – Aug 23	Build (recovery)	8 mi	2,250	_____	_____	☐
9	Aug 24 – Aug 30	Build	14 mi	2,300	_____	_____	☐
10	Aug 31 – Sep 6	Build	15 mi	2,350	_____	_____	☐
11	Sep 7 – Sep 13	Peak	17 mi	2,400	_____	_____	☐
12	Sep 14 – Sep 20	Peak	18 mi	2,450	_____	_____	☐
13	Sep 21 – Sep 27	Peak	20 mi	2,500	_____	_____	☐
14	Sep 28 – Oct 4	Peak (recovery)	12 mi	2,300	_____	_____	☐
15	Oct 5 – Oct 11	Taper	10 mi	2,100	_____	_____	☐
16	Oct 12 – Oct 18	Taper / RACE	4 mi + 26.2!	2,200 (carb-load Thu-Sat)	_____	_____	☐

Recipe Library

13 recipes, used and rotated across all 16 weeks. Each lists macros **per serving**; scale servings by phase using the table above. All recipes are written for **4 servings** unless noted — halve or double as needed.

Chicken

1. Lemon-Herb Grilled Chicken & Quinoa Bowl - *Per serving:* 420 cal | 42g protein | 35g carb | 11g fat - **Ingredients:** 4 chicken breasts (6 oz each), 2 lemons (juiced + zested), 3 tbsp olive oil, 3 cloves garlic (minced), 1 tbsp dried oregano, 1 cup quinoa (dry), 2 cups baby spinach, 1 cup cherry tomatoes (halved), 1/2 cucumber (diced), 1/4 cup feta, salt & pepper - **Prep:** Whisk lemon juice/zest, 2 tbsp olive oil, garlic, oregano, salt, pepper. Marinate chicken 30 min (or overnight). Cook quinoa per package directions. Grill or pan-sear chicken 6–7 min per side until 165°F internal. Rest 5 min, slice. Toss spinach, tomatoes, cucumber with remaining olive oil. Build bowls: quinoa, veggies, chicken, feta on top.

2. Sheet-Pan Chicken Fajita Bowls - *Per serving:* 395 cal | 40g protein | 32g carb | 10g fat - **Ingredients:** 1.5 lb chicken thighs (boneless, skinless, sliced), 2 bell peppers (sliced), 1 red onion (sliced), 2 tbsp olive oil, 2 tsp chili powder, 1 tsp cumin, 1 tsp smoked paprika, 1 cup brown rice (dry), 1 lime, cilantro, salt - **Prep:** Preheat oven 425°F. Toss chicken, peppers, onion with oil and spices on a sheet pan. Roast 20–22 min, stirring halfway. Cook rice per package directions. Squeeze lime over everything, top with cilantro. Serve over rice.

3. Chicken & White Bean Skillet Stew - *Per serving:* 380 cal | 38g protein | 30g carb | 9g fat - **Ingredients:** 1.5 lb chicken breast (cubed), 1 can (15oz) white beans (drained), 1 can (14.5oz) diced tomatoes, 1 onion (diced), 2 carrots (diced), 2 cloves garlic, 2 cups chicken broth, 1 tsp Italian seasoning, 1 tbsp olive oil, 2 cups kale (chopped), salt & pepper - **Prep:** Sauté onion, carrots, garlic in olive oil 5 min. Add chicken, brown 4–5 min. Add tomatoes, beans, broth, seasoning. Simmer 15 min. Stir in kale last 3 min until wilted. Season to taste.

4. Baked Honey-Mustard Chicken Thighs with Roasted Potatoes - *Per serving:* 440 cal | 39g protein | 38g carb | 13g fat - **Ingredients:** 8 chicken thighs (bone-in, skin-on), 3 tbsp Dijon mustard, 2 tbsp honey, 1 tbsp olive oil, 1 lb baby potatoes (halved), 1 tsp garlic powder, 1 tsp paprika, fresh thyme, salt & pepper - **Prep:** Preheat oven 400°F. Whisk mustard, honey, 1 tbsp olive oil. Toss potatoes separately with remaining oil, garlic powder, paprika, salt. Arrange chicken and potatoes on a sheet pan, brush chicken with honey-mustard glaze. Bake 35–40 min until chicken hits 175°F and potatoes are tender. Top with thyme.

Pork

5. Pork Tenderloin with Roasted Sweet Potato & Green Beans - *Per serving:* 410 cal | 38g protein | 34g carb | 12g fat - **Ingredients:** 1.5 lb pork tenderloin, 2 tbsp olive oil, 1 tbsp smoked paprika, 1 tsp garlic powder, 2 medium sweet potatoes (cubed), 1 lb green beans (trimmed), salt & pepper - **Prep:** Preheat oven 425°F. Rub pork with 1 tbsp oil, paprika, garlic powder, salt, pepper. Sear in an oven-safe skillet 2 min per side, then roast 15–18 min until internal temp hits 145°F; rest 5 min. Toss sweet potato and green beans with remaining oil, salt, pepper; roast on a separate sheet pan 20–25 min. Slice pork, serve with vegetables.

6. Pork & Vegetable Stir-Fry - *Per serving:* 390 cal | 36g protein | 33g carb | 11g fat - **Ingredients:** 1.5 lb pork loin (thin-sliced), 2 tbsp low-sodium soy sauce, 1 tbsp rice vinegar, 1 tbsp honey, 1 tsp sesame oil, 2 cups broccoli florets, 1 red bell pepper (sliced), 1 carrot (julienned), 2 cloves garlic, 1 tsp ginger (minced), 1 cup jasmine rice (dry), 1 tbsp vegetable oil - **Prep:** Cook rice per package directions. Whisk soy sauce, vinegar, honey, sesame oil. Heat vegetable oil in a wok/large skillet over high heat. Stir-fry pork 3–4 min until browned; remove. Stir-fry vegetables, garlic, ginger 4–5 min until crisp-tender. Return pork, add sauce, toss 1–2 min. Serve over rice.

7. Slow Cooker Pork Chili - *Per serving:* 400 cal | 35g protein | 36g carb | 12g fat - **Ingredients:** 1.5 lb pork shoulder (trimmed, cubed) or lean ground pork, 1 can (15oz) black beans, 1 can (15oz) kidney beans, 1 can (28oz) crushed tomatoes, 1 onion (diced), 2 cloves garlic, 2 tbsp chili powder, 1 tbsp cumin, 1 bell pepper (diced), salt & pepper - **Prep:** Combine everything in a slow cooker. Cook on low 7–8 hrs or high 4 hrs, until pork shreds easily. Shred pork with two forks, stir back in. Serve with a small portion of brown rice or cornbread on long-run days for extra carbs.

Beef

8. Lean Ground Beef & Sweet Potato Skillet - *Per serving:* 415 cal | 37g protein | 35g carb | 13g fat - **Ingredients:** 1.5 lb lean ground beef (93/7), 2 medium sweet potatoes (diced small), 1 onion (diced), 2 cups baby spinach, 2 cloves garlic, 1 tsp cumin, 1 tsp smoked paprika, 1 tbsp olive oil, salt & pepper - **Prep:** Heat olive oil in a large skillet, cook sweet potato cubes covered 8–10 min, stirring occasionally, until just tender. Push to the side, brown beef with onion and garlic 6–7 min. Add spices, mix everything together. Stir in spinach until wilted, season to taste.

9. Beef & Broccoli over Rice - *Per serving:* 405 cal | 36g protein | 38g carb | 10g fat - **Ingredients:** 1.5 lb flank steak (thin-sliced against the grain), 3 cups broccoli florets, 3 tbsp low-sodium soy sauce, 1 tbsp oyster sauce, 1 tbsp cornstarch, 1 tbsp brown sugar, 2 cloves garlic, 1 tsp ginger, 1 cup jasmine rice (dry), 1 tbsp vegetable oil - **Prep:** Cook rice per package directions. Whisk soy sauce, oyster sauce, cornstarch, brown sugar, garlic, ginger. Sear beef in hot oiled skillet/wok 2–3 min until just browned; remove. Stir-fry broccoli 4 min until crisp-tender, adding a splash of water to steam if needed. Return beef, add sauce, toss until thickened (1–2 min). Serve over rice.

10. Baked Meatballs with Marinara & Whole-Wheat Pasta - *Per serving:* 450 cal | 35g protein | 42g carb | 14g fat - **Ingredients:** 1.5 lb lean ground beef (93/7), 1/3 cup breadcrumbs, 1 egg, 1/4 cup grated parmesan, 2 cloves garlic (minced), 1 tsp Italian seasoning, 24 oz marinara sauce (low sugar), 8 oz whole-wheat pasta, fresh basil, salt & pepper - **Prep:** Preheat oven 400°F. Mix beef, breadcrumbs, egg, parmesan, garlic, seasoning, salt, pepper. Roll into 16 meatballs, bake on a lined sheet pan 18–20 min. Meanwhile, cook pasta per package directions and warm marinara. Combine meatballs with sauce, serve over pasta, top with basil.

Fish

11. Baked Salmon with Roasted Asparagus & Brown Rice - *Per serving:* 430 cal | 36g protein | 32g carb | 17g fat - **Ingredients:** 4 salmon fillets (6 oz each), 1 bunch asparagus (trimmed), 2 tbsp olive oil, 1 lemon, 2 cloves garlic (minced), 1 cup brown rice (dry), salt & pepper, fresh dill - **Prep:** Preheat oven 400°F. Cook rice per package directions. Toss asparagus with 1 tbsp oil, salt, pepper on a sheet pan. Place salmon on the same pan, brush with remaining oil, garlic, lemon juice, salt, pepper. Bake 12–15 min until salmon flakes easily. Top with dill and lemon zest, serve over rice.

12. Pan-Seared Cod Tacos with Cabbage Slaw - *Per serving:* 360 cal | 32g protein | 38g carb | 8g fat - **Ingredients:** 1.5 lb cod fillets, 1 tsp chili powder, 1 tsp cumin, 8 small corn tortillas, 2 cups shredded cabbage, 1/4 cup Greek yogurt, 1 lime, 1 tbsp olive oil, cilantro, hot sauce (optional) - **Prep:** Season cod with chili powder, cumin, salt. Sear in olive oil 3–4 min per side until flaky. Flake into large pieces. Mix cabbage with Greek yogurt, lime juice, salt for slaw. Warm tortillas, fill with cod and slaw, top with cilantro and hot sauce.

13. Shrimp & Vegetable Skewers with Couscous - *Per serving:* 370 cal | 33g protein | 36g carb | 9g fat - **Ingredients:** 1.5 lb large shrimp (peeled, deveined), 1 zucchini (sliced), 1 red bell pepper (chunked), 1 red onion (chunked), 2 tbsp olive oil, 1 tsp smoked paprika, 1 tsp garlic powder, 1 cup couscous (dry), 1 lemon, parsley, salt & pepper -

Prep: Soak skewers if wooden. Toss shrimp and vegetables with olive oil, paprika, garlic powder, salt. Thread onto skewers alternating shrimp and vegetables. Grill or broil 3–4 min per side until shrimp is opaque. Prepare couscous per package directions, fluff with lemon juice and parsley. Serve skewers over couscous.

Weekly Meal Plan Template (Repeats Every Week — Portions Scale by Phase)

This 7-day rotation uses the recipe library above. Lunches lean on dinner leftovers to minimize cooking. Breakfast and snacks stay simple and consistent so the only real variable each week is portion size and long-run-day carb add-ons.

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Snack
Mon	Greek yogurt, berries, granola, 1 tbsp honey	Leftover Recipe #4 or #8 (from weekend)	Recipe #1 — Lemon-Herb Chicken & Quinoa Bowl	Apple + 1 oz almonds
Tue	Oatmeal with banana, peanut butter, cinnamon	Leftover Recipe #1	Recipe #6 — Pork & Vegetable Stir-Fry	Cottage cheese + pineapple
Wed	3-egg veggie omelet, whole-grain toast	Leftover Recipe #6	Recipe #9 — Beef & Broccoli over Rice	Greek yogurt + honey
Thu	Smoothie: protein powder, spinach, banana, oat milk	Leftover Recipe #9	Recipe #11 — Baked Salmon, Asparagus, Brown Rice	Rice cakes + almond butter
Fri	Overnight oats with chia, berries	Leftover Recipe #11	Recipe #2 — Sheet-Pan Chicken Fajita Bowls	Hummus + carrots/cucumber
Sat (long run)	Toast + banana + honey (pre-run); full breakfast post-run: eggs + potatoes	Recipe #5 or #8 (fresh-cooked, larger carb side)	Recipe #10 — Baked Meatballs & Pasta (carb-up dinner)	Chocolate milk or recovery shake post-run
Sun (prep day)	Pancakes or French toast (treat-ish, planned)	Recipe #12 or #13 (fresh)	Recipe #3 or #7 (batch-cook extra for Mon/Tue leftovers)	Trail mix

Rotate which recipes land on which day every 2–3 weeks so you're not eating the exact same thing every single Tuesday for 16 weeks — the chart above is a structure, not a cage.

Weekly Grocery Shopping List

Use this master list each week; check off the column matching your current phase since portion-driven quantities shift. Pantry basics (olive oil, spices, garlic, salt/pepper) are assumed stocked — only restock when low.

Item	Base Phase (wks 1-4)	Build Phase (wks 5-10)	Peak Phase (wks 11-14)	Taper Phase (wks 15-16)
Chicken breast/thighs	2.5 lb	3 lb	3.5 lb	2.5 lb
Pork (tenderloin/loin/shoulder)	1.5 lb	2 lb	2 lb	1.5 lb
Lean ground beef / flank steak	1.5 lb	2 lb	2.5 lb	1.5 lb
Salmon / cod / shrimp	1.5 lb	2 lb	2 lb	1.5 lb
Eggs	1 dozen	1.5 dozen	1.5 dozen	1 dozen
Greek yogurt	32 oz	32 oz	48 oz	32 oz
Cottage cheese	16 oz	16 oz	16 oz	16 oz
Quinoa / brown rice / jasmine rice	2 cups dry	3 cups dry	4 cups dry	3 cups dry
Whole-wheat pasta	8 oz	8 oz	16 oz	8 oz
Couscous	1 cup	1 cup	1 cup	1 cup
Sweet potatoes / potatoes	3 lb	4 lb	5 lb	3 lb
Oats	1 canister	1 canister	1 canister	1 canister
Bananas	7-10	10-12	12-14	8-10
Berries (fresh/frozen)	2 pints	2 pints	3 pints	2 pints
Spinach / kale	2 bags	2 bags	3 bags	2 bags
Broccoli	2 heads/bags	3 heads/bags	3 heads/bags	2 heads/bags
Bell peppers	4	5	6	4
Onions	3	4	4	3
Garlic	1 head	1 head	1 head	1 head
Canned beans (black/white/kidney)	2 cans	3 cans	3 cans	2 cans
Canned tomatoes/marinara	2 cans/jars	2 cans/jars	3 cans/jars	2 cans/jars
Almonds / mixed nuts	1 bag	1 bag	1 bag	1 bag
Peanut/almond butter	1 jar (lasts weeks)	—	—	—
Lemons/limes	4	5	6	4
Chocolate milk or recovery shake mix	1 (long-run days)	2	2	1

Carb-Loading Plan: Race Week (Week 16)

Day	Focus
Mon-Wed	Normal taper eating, mileage very low
Thu	Begin shifting toward carbs: rice, pasta, potatoes, bread; slightly reduce fat/fiber
Fri	Carb-heavy, moderate portions, low fiber/fat to avoid GI issues — pasta, rice, white bread, bananas
Sat	Final carb-load: familiar, low-fiber, high-carb dinner (e.g., Recipe #10 with extra pasta, light sauce); hydrate well; avoid new foods
Sun – RACE DAY	Familiar pre-run breakfast (toast, banana, honey) 2–3 hrs before start; sip sports drink; post-race: protein + carbs within 60 min (recovery shake, then a real meal)

Quick Tips

- **Weigh in 1x/week**, same morning conditions, and track a 7-day average — daily fluctuation from training and sodium will otherwise mislead you.
- **Never run a long run (10+ mi) underfueled** to "save calories" — eat the extra carbs on those days; the chart above already builds this in.
- **Hydration:** aim for pale-yellow urine; add electrolytes on hot long-run days regardless of diet phase.
- **Protein at every meal** (aim 30–40g) helps satiety in a deficit and supports muscle recovery from running volume.
- If 2 consecutive weigh-ins show no movement and energy/runs feel fine, that's normal — don't panic-cut calories further; trust the weekly average trend over 3–4 weeks.

This plan provides general nutrition guidance for an endurance training context and isn't a substitute for advice from a registered dietitian or your physician — check in with one if you have any underlying health conditions, are taking medications, or the deficit isn't sitting well with your training.